# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

The White House said **Steve Witkoff** and **Jared Kushner**, two of Donald Trump's top envoys, would meet with **Iranian** officials in Islamabad on Saturday for talks. Earlier, Iranian state media said Iran's foreign minister would travel to the Pakistani capital. Mr Trump has insisted on maintaining a naval blockade of Iranian ports and shipping until Iran makes a deal.

America's **Department of Justice** dropped its criminal probe into **Jerome Powell**. The decision removes a major obstacle for Kevin Warsh, Donald Trump's pick, to succeed him as chair of the Federal Reserve. A Republican senator had promised to hold up his nomination while the investigation was under way, arguing it interfered with the central bank's independence.

Fighting between **Israel** and **Hizbullah** intensified a day after Mr Trump announced that a ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon would be extended for three weeks. Israel launched air strikes in southern Lebanon after issuing evacuation warnings, while Hizbullah said it fired rockets and drones at Israeli forces. The militant group said the ceasefire was "meaningless".

**Google** agreed to invest up to $40bn in **Anthropic**, including an initial $10bn, in a huge funding deal for the AI lab. The deal values

the company at about $350bn and reflects the vast spending needed to build and run advanced AI systems. Google already supplies Anthropic with chips and cloud services, even as it develops its own competing models.

**DeepSeek**, a Chinese AI firm, unveiled a preview of its new open-source model, v4. The company claims it outperformed all other open-source models in world-knowledge benchmarking, trailing only closed-source models like Google's Gemini. DeepSeek is moving away from reliance on Nvidia chips. Unlike previous models, v4 has been adapted for Huawei's chips.

**Britain** said the **Falkland Islands'** sovereignty was "not in question" following reports that America may reconsider its diplomatic backing for Britain's claim. The idea appeared in a leaked Pentagon email outlining ways to punish NATO allies that refused to support strikes on Iran. Argentina's president, Javier Milei, said this week he would do "everything humanly possible" to return the islands to Argentine control.

**America's Space Force** awarded contracts worth up to $3.2bn to 12 companies to develop space-based missile interceptors, part of Mr Trump's "Golden Dome" defence plan. The idea is to place systems in orbit that can spot and hit missiles soon after they are launched, rather than waiting to intercept them later using ground-based defences.

**Figure of the day: $585m,** the value of Chinese whisky sold overseas last year, up from $5m a decade earlier. Read more about how the tipple is thriving.

Photograph: AP

## Not so sweet Virginia

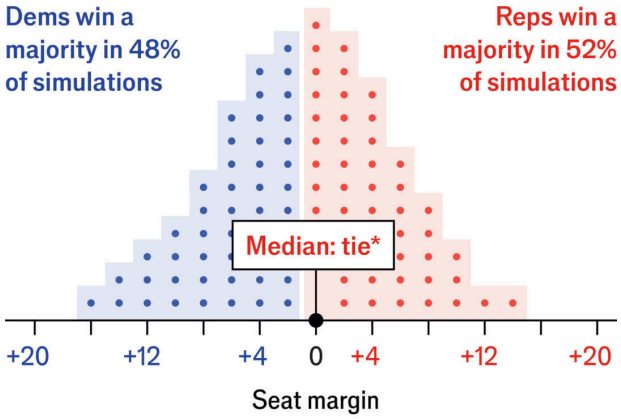
The Republican Party's hopes of maintaining control of America's House of Representatives were already slim. Voters in Virginia may have destroyed them. On Tuesday they passed a referendum that will gerrymander three or four of the party's incumbents out of their seats. In *The Economist's* statistical forecast of this year's Congressional elections, the result in Virginia increased Democrats' average expected seats in the 435-seat chamber from 232 to 235, and their probability of a majority from 94% to 98%.

The Senate, meanwhile, is on a knife's edge. The list of seats up for election favours Republicans: Democrats need to gain four for a majority, including in at least two states that Donald Trump won by double digits in 2024. Don't count the Democrats out yet, though. They lead national polls by six percentage points. They have also recruited strong candidates in Alaska, North Carolina and Ohio. Our model suggests the Dems have a 48% chance of flipping both chambers.

## US Senate forecast

**At Apr 22nd 2026**

One dot=100 simulated elections




*The Republican vice-president, J.D. Vance, breaks ties

Source: *The Economist*'s midterm election model

Photograph: Reuters

## Chinese EVs in the fast lane

Hundreds of thousands of visitors and hundreds of exhibitors will race to Beijing this weekend for one of the world's biggest motor shows. Over ten days at the Beijing Auto Show, Chinese battery- and EV-makers will debut new models and technologies. Ahead of the show CATL, the world's largest battery-maker, unveiled a new battery that it claims can be recharged from 10% to 90% in six minutes, beating BYD's best effort of nine. (Both say their batteries deliver around 1,000km of range.)

The show comes at an opportune moment. The war in Iran has pushed up petrol prices, making alternatives more desirable. But China's EV market has descended into a savage, three-year price war, caused by chronic overcapacity. As a result, Chinese automakers are increasingly looking to go global. China already makes roughly 70% of the world's EVs and 85% of its battery-cells. The Beijing Auto Show will reveal how much further its firms are pulling ahead of the pack.

Photograph: EPA

## What sort of change will America bring about in Cuba?

America's deadline for Cuba to release some political prisoners is Friday. That is one of several demands, not all of them clearly stated, that the Trump administration is making of Cuba's communist regime. It imposed an oil blockade on the island in January. The two governments reportedly held secret talks on April 10th in Havana. If Cuba releases the prisoners further negotiations may take place. If not, the Trump administration may increase the pressure.

Among its demands is reform of Cuba's centrally planned economy. Most Cubans would welcome that. Now they suffer from food shortages, power cuts and deteriorating health care, all of which are made worse by the blockade. Liberalisation would also provide opportunities for American business. Less clear is whether the Trump administration means to force the regime out of power. Its leaders are savvy: they will try to lessen the pressure by making concessions while seeking to stay in control.

Photograph: Lionsgate

## “Michael”: it’s Bad

A film about an eccentric megastar—who made fans swoon and befriended a chimpanzee—should not be dull. Yet “Michael”, a biopic of Michael Jackson released in American cinemas on Friday, contrives to be. Starring the singer’s nephew, Jaafar Jackson, it recounts the rise of the Jackson 5, then Michael’s struggle to escape his despotic father, Joseph (Colman Domingo), while accumulating exotic pets and idolising Peter Pan. As Jackson is to his devotees, this version of him is a saint, whose destiny is to “spread love and joy” and “heal” people.

The main event is the music, which is as wondrous as ever. Despite the allegations of child abuse that dogged Jackson in the years before his death in 2009, his greatest songs have proved uncancellable. Since the plot ends before those accusations emerged, they go unmentioned in this nauseating movie. “His story continues,” reads a closing note. Indeed it did.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

# Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [email protected]. We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

**Friday:** Which medieval kingdom in the Persian gulf was ruled by descendants of Muhammad Diramku?

**Thursday:** Which Malaysian state is bordered by Negeri Sembilan to the north and Johor to the east?

*The lack of a sense of history is the damnation of the modern world.*

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***Robert Penn Warren***